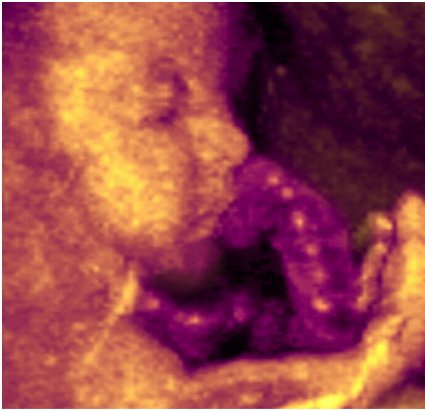




YOU ARE **25 WEEKS AND 2 DAYS**

103 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

This image shows the baby in profile, this time in 3-D. The coils of the umbilical cord are just seen in the background passing behind the baby's head. The eyelids can be seen, still firmly closed. Fat reserves are now giving the face a much more rounded contour.

“Two tiny glands control your baby's growth and development, and enable them to face up to life's stresses.”

Relative to body size, your baby's adrenal glands are 20 times larger than your own. The adrenal glands are roughly triangular in shape, with their base wrapped over the top of each kidney. They have an outer layer, or cortex, which releases steroid hormones such as cortisol, and an inner layer, or medulla. Adrenaline and the related hormone noradrenaline are secreted from the medulla in response to stress.

Adrenaline prepares the body for a “fight or flight” response, increasing the availability of glucose, speeding up the heart rate, and maintaining or raising blood pressure. These are vital adaptive responses for your baby that will help to maintain a stable environment within the uterus and prepare them for the stresses of life later on in the outside world.

It is the outer cortex, however, that needs to work hard, producing many hormones that help to coordinate your baby's growth and development. The cortex produces three types of hormones: mineralocorticoids that regulate salt balance; glucocorticoids that help to control the availability of sugars, fat, and amino acids in the bloodstream; and androgens, male-type sex hormones, such as testosterone. It is the cortex that accounts for the large size of your baby's adrenal glands. After birth, in the first couple of weeks, the adrenal glands rapidly reduce in size.

ASK A DOCTOR

I have lumps in my breasts. Should I be worried? Breast lumps can be normal in pregnancy, especially in the third trimester as the breasts get ready for breast-feeding. These lumps are generally soft and may move around; they may also be tender. If you are feeling a new lump, let your doctor know. They will be able to confirm whether this is pregnancy related.

HOW IDENTICAL ARE TWINS?

Twins from the same egg have the same DNA. They will certainly look very similar and have the same hair, eye, and skin color. They will also have the same blood group and tissue type.